

THE TOUR

EPISODE 2

TEAMMATES

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V2 August 2025

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1

INT. WAITING ROOM - KOREAN SOVEREIGN WEALTH FUND - PARIS - DAY

NORA, dressed as a businesswoman, is sitting with RAPHAËL opposite a secretary in a waiting room. They speak French discreetly.

RAPHAËL

You did add "Chairwoman" to your business card, right?

NORA

Yes, don't worry.

RAPHAËL

It's important that you have the same protocol rank.

NORA

(mischievously)

Except that she's worth a trillion.

RAPHAËL

(still deadly serious)

Give her your card with both hands, thumbs at the top, and most importantly, never interrupt her.

NORA

Alright, I've got it.

RAPHAËL

I'm serious! The Koreans are very attached to conventions and they hate to lose face. You won't get another chance, so follow protocol...

NORA

(interrupting, forcefully)

I told you, I've got it.

The door opens and an assistant appears.

MS YEO'S ASSISTANT

Ms Yeo is ready to receive you and your assistant.

NORA nods, she has a determined expression. RAPHAËL doesn't take kindly to being put in his place.

2

INT. MEETING ROOM - KOREAN SOVEREIGN WEALTH FUND - PARIS - DAY

NORA is sitting opposite MS YEO in the middle of a huge table in a meeting room overlooking the Eiffel Tower. The meeting begins. It is held in English.

RAPHAËL is facing a screen showing graphs and charts that demonstrate how NORA will turn the business around. He wraps up his presentation.

RAPHAËL

...thanks to the intervention of Ms Menia and the organisational changes she is making, the company will achieve positive EBITDA for the first time in 5 years. We have strengthened relations with our sponsors, we have a full, balanced team of riders.

(concluding)

Deepblue is on track for making world cycling history in the next 10 years.

The assistants nod. NORA smiles discreetly at RAPHAËL. There's a long silence. Finally MS YEO speaks.

MS YEO

(only addressing NORA)

We are impressed by the way you have turned this business around.

Heavy silence.

MS YEO (CONT'D)

In my country, we are very attached to traditions and your team is an important part of French heritage.

Long silence.

MS YEO (CONT'D)

Unfortunately, we are not interested in the assets you presented. We are here for another reason...

NORA jumps in and interrupts her.

NORA

The World Tour.

MS YEO is gobsmacked that someone would cut her off. RAPHAËL and the assistants are appalled. Tension in the air.

MS YEO speaks again.

MS YEO

That's right, the World Tour. That is the only thing that we are interested in.

Tension. They enter a staring contest.

NORA
(tackling head on)
In that case, what price would you
put on a part of French heritage?

MS YEO cracks a smile. The real negotiations have begun.

CUT TO:

SERIES TITLE

3 **EXT. MUR DE BRETAGNE HILL - DAY**

VAN DER POEL, BARDET, POGACAR, HOFFMAN... The road is still painted with the names that have marked the history of the TOUR DE FRANCE in this legendary place.

It's the last training session before the *grand départ*. Our 8 selected Tour cyclists are beginning a slow but steep ascent. MATHIAS is protected by 2 riders in the middle of the group. JOSÉ is in the lead, setting the pace. AYDEN finally appears at the rear.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
(from his radio)
Imagine we're at the foot of a
mountain pass, push Mathias
forward, but go as fast as possible
to block any attacks. Stay
together!

We see AYDEN break away a few metres from the group. The climb begins. It's strenuous, laborious and chaotic. Nobody seems to have found their place in the group. MATHIAS looks back, sees AYDEN, gets annoyed and shouts.

MATHIAS
We said together! What are you
doing back there, Ayden!

4 **INT/EXT. DEEPBLUE CAR - MUR DE BRETAGNE HILL - DAY**

ERIK is at the wheel of the Deepblue car following the cyclists. He looks worried. JENNA is sitting beside him.

ERIK
We're doomed. It's great that we're
in the Tour, but we're just not
ready.

JENNA
It's a 3-week event, they'll
develop new habits as they go
along.

ERIK

They have to begin at full
throttle. We can't afford to lose
time at the start.

JENNA

A race can go any way! Take Froome
in the 2018 Giro, he managed to...

ERIK

(cutting her off)

We're not Team Sky, Jenna! And have
you seen who we're up against?
Galactic has been crushing everyone
since the season started. With
their money, they have a massive
collective. Every one of their
riders could be a leader elsewhere.

JENNA has to admit he's right.

ERIK (CONT'D)

And above all, they have Andrea. He
knows everything about us, about
Mathias. His strengths and his
weaknesses...

JENNA

What do we do?

ERIK thinks.

ERIK

Surprise them. If we approach it as
usual we won't stand a chance. We
have to switch into guerrilla mode.
If Mathias isn't in the top 10 by
the end of the first week, it's
over.

JENNA takes in the information.

5

EXT. MUR DE BRETAGNE HILL - DAY

Suddenly, AYDEN makes a sharp attack, leaving the rest of the
team behind.

The other cyclists shout at him. MATHIAS is furious. GAËL
starts chasing AYDEN, then MAËL follows.

We can hear ERIK losing it through the earpiece.

ERIK

Don't just sit there! Get a move on
for fuck's sake! Work as a team!

The race to the sign continues. AYDEN reaches the top and mimes a glorious victory, raising his arms.

He comes to a stop and is joined by the other team cyclists, JENNA, ERIK and the rest of the caravan.

AYDEN
(joking, mimicking a
commentator)
An extraordinary race by Ayden
Legrand who brought the rest of the
Deepblue team to their knees...
Ayden, this Tour de...

MATHIAS
Why the fuck did you do that?!

AYDEN
(cheekily)
Because I can.

ERIK arrives, looking furious.

ERIK
The next person who ignores my
instructions is out! Got it!?

AYDEN
I was just having a laugh, coach.

ERIK
We're not here to have a laugh,
goddammit! Cycling's not some game!

Everyone is speechless. MATHIAS has an evil look on his face.

ERIK (CONT'D)
(turning towards the
twins)
He's just a rookie. But you two,
Dumb and Dumber, you're meant to be
pros!

MAËL
(gutted)
Ayden's a pro too!

GAËL
He's the one being a dick and we
take the flack?!

ERIK
The Tour starts on Saturday and
you're all completely delirious!
You have no clue!

MATHIAS takes in the boss's words.

MATHIAS

We won't win the Tour in the first week. But if we don't work as a team from the start, we'll definitely lose.

No-one says a word. Everyone realises the stakes. MATHIAS turns towards AYDEN and the TWINS.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

Since you still have legs, you can use them to cycle home.

ERIK nods in approval and starts driving back.

RÉDA

Brest is that way!

MAËL

You're kidding, right!? It's 130 kilometre away!

The cars drive away leaving the furious brothers looking at each other. AYDEN realises he's messed up.

6

INT. KITCHEN / LIVING ROOM - RAPHAËL'S APARTMENT - PARIS - DAY

RAPHAËL opens a bottle of champagne and pours it into two overflowing glasses in an open kitchen looking onto an elegant Parisian living room. NORA is sitting on the worktop.

RAPHAËL

You're brilliant! How did you come up with the idea of the World Tour?

NORA

(smiling)

It's *the* elite pro cycling race. Your ticket to the world's biggest races. Now that's a fucking soft power tool! Politics on the cheap.

RAPHAËL

Cheap?! If it works you'll be pocketing 4 million in profit!

NORA cracks a smile and takes another swig of champagne.

NORA

If Mathias makes the Top 3, we'll be in the World Tour again and I can sell them the team.

(cheekily)

We'd cash in the 4 million, and you'd get your 300K com', so yeah.

RAPHAËL
Is it feasible?

NORA
Impossible to tell. The Tour lasts
three weeks, and so many things can
happen...
(meditatively)
But I think it is. Mathias is
really exceptional.

RAPHAËL
(smiling)
As exceptional as me?

NORA smirks, RAPHAËL moves close, he kisses her and starts to
lift up her top.

RAPHAËL (CONT'D)
I've never wanted that jerk to win
so much!

NORA raises her eyebrows suggesting that the comment was
uncalled for.

RAPHAËL (CONT'D)
(scornful)
Looks like your mechanics just need
to learn Korean.

NORA
They're not interested in the
team... Yeo will shut down the
French setup to turn it into the
first all-Asian World Tour team.

RAPHAËL
(cynical)
So Mathias' success would spell the
end of his team...

NORA thinks and nods gravely.

RAPHAËL (CONT'D)
Wouldn't you feel anything at all?

NORA
(mischievously)
I wouldn't. I'm heartless.

RAPHAËL kisses her even more passionately, they get ready to
have sex on the countertop.

7

INT. THIBAUT'S HOSPITAL ROOM - BREST - DAY

MATHIAS, RÉDA and VICTOR walk into THIBAUT's room.

We can see that he only has one leg, the other has been amputated.

JENNA is at his bedside. THIBAUT smiles as soon as he sees his mates and tries to sit up. JENNA kisses THIBAUT and strokes him.

JENNA
I'll leave you to it, but no bike talk!

The cyclists look doubtful.

JENNA (CONT'D)
Just kidding! None of you are capable of talking about anything else anyway.

Everyone smiles.

RÉDA
How are you doing papa'?

THIBAUT
(wanting to seem positive)
Good! The doc did a good job.

VICTOR
Look on the bright side. It'll take you half the time to shave your legs!

RÉDA
(shocked)
Oh! Show some respect!

THIBAUT smiles to show them that the joke went down well.

MATHIAS, who hasn't said a word since they arrived, stays at the back. He struggles to smile, still shocked by his mate's amputation.

THIBAUT sees him. The tables turn, he tries to reassure him.

THIBAUT
(to Mathias)
Hey Mathias, it'll be alright... You know, it was a relief when they cut it off. The pain, the infections... I couldn't handle it any more. It's a relief, honestly.

MATHIAS manages to smile but unconvincingly.

THIBAUT (CONT'D)
And they make incredible artificial limbs now. In three months, I'll be taking you all out.

RÉDA
Alpe d'Huez, bro! Remember how you
crushed them all!!

THIBAUT smiles but then has a sudden coughing fit.

THIBAUT
Ah, I still can't wait to get out
of here. You catch all sorts of
shit in the hospital.

A nurse enters to take care of his wounds. The cyclists take
the opportunity to leave.

RÉDA
See you on the Champs! You better
be there.

THIBAUT
Promise.

VICTOR
It'll be your round this time!

THIBAUT winks and smiles. RÉDA and VICTOR leave the room.
THIBAUT calls back MATHIAS.

THIBAUT
Hey Mathias. It's not your fault,
alright?

MATHIAS nods unconvincingly.

THIBAUT (CONT'D)
I'm serious. The fall was
collective. Forget about the rest.

MATHIAS nods shyly. We can feel his sense of guilt.

THIBAUT (CONT'D)
Focus on the *grand départ*. No
looking back.

MATHIAS thinks about it for a long time.

8 **INT. LIVING ROOM / MATHIAS' HOUSE - NIGHT**

MATHIAS is in his living room where the bay windows overlook
the sea. He's looking at the shelves of trophies summing up
his career. It's an impressive collection.

KATRINE comes and sits next to him. She looks at the trophies
too.

KATRINE
(melancholic)
Funny how the victories stay with
us but the defeats seem to fade
away.

MATHIAS
What are you doing here?
If you're looking for Andrea, he
doesn't live here.

KATRINE doesn't say a word.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
What do you want?

KATRINE
I saw Marcel this afternoon.

MATHIAS tenses up. Silence.

KATRINE (CONT'D)
He's not doing well.

MATHIAS
(explosive)
For fuck's sake, you think I don't
know that?! The Tour is about to
start, I have to be 100% focused! I
can't be distracted by...

KATRINE
(interrupting)
Distracted?! Have you heard
yourself? We're talking about your
son! And his fears.

MATHIAS
All kids are afraid of things. What
about kids whose parents are
firefighters and cops?!

KATRINE
They don't watch their father crash
live on TV!

MATHIAS
(beside himself)
What am I meant to do, then?! Give
up cycling?! Roll out the red
carpet for Andrea? I'm not that
stupid.

KATRINE doesn't answer. After a while.

KATRINE
(calmly)
You're 35, Mathias. You've won
almost everything...

MATHIAS
"Almost".

KATRINE
... if you were meant to win the
Tour, don't you think you would
have by now?

We can see anger in MATHIAS' eyes. After a while.

KATRINE (CONT'D)
(calmly)
I'm just saying you need to look
after your son.

MATHIAS
Like you look after yours?!

KATRINE doesn't answer

9 **INT/EXT NORA'S CAR BREST DOCKS - NIGHT**

NORA is driving along the docks when she notices a young guy
doing tricks on a BMX/trial bike then falling off.

NORA
I don't believe it!

NORA turns towards the guy who is back on his bike and doing
another set of tricks. He falls off again, it's AYDEN.

NORA calls him from the car. AYDEN turns around in surprise.

NORA (CONT'D)
What are you doing!?

AYDEN
(as if it were obvious)
I'm doing tricks!

NORA
We leave in two days and you're
trying to break your bones?!

AYDEN is fuming. He sighs but doesn't say a word.

NORA (CONT'D)
Put your bike in the back. I'm
taking you back.

INT/EXT. MATHIAS' CAR - STREETS OF BREST - NIGHT

AYDEN is sitting in the front passenger seat. NORA is driving.

AYDEN

(furious)

I can't do anything! Like those training sessions! They're so fucking boring! You just have to sit there, keep your mouth shut and listen all the time. Like a robot. But I'm nobody's robot. Erik and Mathias spend their life holding me back! Isn't the whole point of cycling to go as fast as possible?

NORA

(dryly)

So they say...

AYDEN

It's not my fault if I'm faster than everyone else!

NORA is getting increasingly irritated, this time she's firmer.

NORA

You're good. Nobody said the contrary. But you have to learn to cycle as part of a team, otherwise it will never work.

AYDEN is silenced by NORA's natural authority.

NORA (CONT'D)

You know, it was Mathias who insisted for you to be in the selection.

AYDEN turns to NORA in surprise.

NORA (CONT'D)

Not many people would have put their bets on you. Not even me at first. And your attitude doesn't help things.

AYDEN is upset.

AYDEN

I didn't ask for any of this!

(glaring)

If you're not happy with me, I'll leave!

NORA
We know you will, we saw that after
Roubaix. But you came back...

AYDEN calms down.

NORA (CONT'D)
...because you want to be here.

AYDEN turns away and thinks.

NORA pushes further.

NORA (CONT'D)
You don't realise just how
important the Tour is to them.

AYDEN listens, his expression is tense, serious.

NORA (CONT'D)
It ruined Mathias' marriage. Victor
missed the birth of his son and
Réda missed his own mother's
funeral...

AYDEN clenches his jaw, his eyes swell with tears despite his
serious expression. NORA doesn't see. She continues. Tears
start to run down AYDEN's face which remains expressionless.

NORA (CONT'D)
They've sacrificed everything for
this race. Your behaviour is just a
show of disrespect to all of them.

NORA turns towards AYDEN and sees the tears flowing.

NORA (CONT'D)
(feeling awkward)
Don't cry, I'm just saying that...

AYDEN
I'm not crying. The tears just
come. It happens sometimes, ever
since I was a kid. I can't control
it.

NORA adopts a gentler tone.

NORA
I think you should talk to
Mathias...

AYDEN confidently wipes away his tears without any emotion.
He looks at the road and the city lights as they roll past
the window, his head leaning against the door.

EXT. BREST HARBOUR - DAY

The next day, a magnificent sailboat cuts through the waves, driven by strong winds under a blazing summer sun.

MATHIAS is at the helm, calm. Another wave crashes. It's intense.

MATHIAS

We're going to tack! I'm going to need your help. Grab the sheet...

We see AYDEN jump into action but he struggles to find the right rope.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

It's the blue rope, there, on the right. No, the blue one.

AYDEN moves around the boat and picks up the right rope.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

Let it go exactly when I say, and grab the leeward sheet, the green one, on the left, and pull as hard as you can to move the front sail. It's going to move quick, so keep on your toes.

MATHIAS turns the wheel to the right, the boat starts to turn.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

That's it. Let go of the sheet!

AYDEN drops the sheet, the sail flaps in the wind, the boat turns, the front sail moves to the other side.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

Now, take the leeway sheet and pull!

AYDEN follows instructions.

The boat tacks, MATHIAS brings the wheel back to the centre.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

Come back over here.

AYDEN joins MATHIAS who gives him the wheel.

AYDEN

Are you sure?

MATHIAS nods in a confident and paternal manner.

The boat picks up speed and starts heeling.

AYDEN (CONT'D)
This is so cool!

MATHIAS nods with a smile.

MATHIAS
Feel how the wind fills the sails
and how the boat reacts? It's like
clockwork. If you face the wind,
you stand still, turn too much, you
risk capsizing.

AYDEN is still at the helm, feeling more connected to the
world than ever.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
It's the same with cycling, it's
about getting the right balance,
positioning yourself in the wheels
of others to save energy, or facing
the wind to make it as hard for
them as possible.

A wave hits them. MATHIAS takes back the wheel with
authority.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
In light winds, there's no danger.
In storms, you can ride it out.
(darker)
But you've got to handle the gusts.

The words sound like a warning. The wind builds. So does the
tension. MATHIAS bears away, hauling in the mainsheet. The
boat begins to heel hard.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
Whoever wins the Tour will be the
one ready to take the biggest
risks.

The boat heels even further. MATHIAS continues his lesson.
AYDEN listens, unflinching despite the danger.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
The one who can push it to the very
limit...

MATHIAS suddenly jerks the wheel hard. The boat is about to
capsize! The tension peaks. AYDEN still shows no fear.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
But you have to cross the
line...alive.

MATHIAS yanks the wheel the other way, eases the sheet, and
the boat rights itself. AYDEN doesn't flinch.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
(more paternal)
You can't sail a boat like this
alone.

AYDEN listens.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
It's the same with the Tour. You
can't win it alone.

AYDEN seems to understand.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
So you know what we call the person
who helps a captain on a boat?

AYDEN shakes his head, captivated by the power of the boat
and the elements.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
A mate, like a teammate.

AYDEN gazes into the distance and thinks about his leader's
words.

CUT TO: BLACK

12 **EXT/INT. PADDOCK - DUSSELDORF GRAND DÉPART - DAY**

The next sequence is a long take.

We follow a man running through miles of cables on the floor
between dozens of vans. He climbs a ladder on a press van to
a mobile studio where twenty or so journalists are commenting
the race in several languages in front of images of the *grand
départ*.

The camera moves up and above the monitor to a window where
we discover, in real life, the sheer scale of the Tour
village before descending into it. It's buzzing everywhere,
the commotion of the last moments before the start of the
race. Competitors, support teams, journalists, politicians,
commentators, sponsors and the general public all rub
shoulders in the paddock of the *grand départ*. It's immense!

We see NORA in "big boss" mode finishing an interview in the
middle of the crowd before going on her way.

NORA walks up to the support cars parked in front of the
Deepblue bus where ERIK is talking about last-minute
instructions with JENNA.

The door of the bus opens. The cyclists walk out in their
racing gear one after the other, ready for the race: GAËL,
MAËL, JOSÉ, RÉDA, then WILLIAM and VICTOR.

MATHIAS appears behind them, looking focused. The sound becomes muffled.

Finally, AYDEN steps out last. He stops a moment, both awestruck and overwhelmed by such a huge event.

CUT TO:

We see MATHIAS at the front of the peloton. He looks focused. AYDEN, who is lost in the mass of the peloton, watches him, intimidated. MATHIAS turns around and winks at him as if to say "It'll be alright".

Each competitor goes into their own world, checks the last technical details. Breathing. Heartbeats.

MATHIAS and ANDREA glare at each other and size each other up.

NORA makes her way to the barriers and sees MATHIAS who is too focused to notice her. She sees AYDEN, who looks intimidated. She smiles at him.

NORA (MIMING)
This is insane.

AYDEN nods and smiles, seemingly reassured.

MATHIAS grips his handlebars, more determined than ever. The very last seconds... they're off. The sound comes back, the click of cleats into pedals, like a round of machine-gun fire. The peloton surges forward.

13 **EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - DUSSELDORF STAGE - DAY**

We are thrown straight into the chaos of the race, at the heart of the peloton which is hurtling past at full speed, brushing the crowds at the roadside. Unlike the TV coverage, we see it from the riders' perspective, down at ground level and at full throttle! Danger looms everywhere and the noise is deafening!

Several crashes unfold in quick succession, riders are already out.

We discover the scale of the event, with helicopters tracking the race, cameras on motorbikes, support cars in pursuit. The pace is brutal from the start!

MATHIAS appears with AYDEN at his side. Both are going flat out, poorly placed in the middle of the peloton.

14 **EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - DUSSELDORF STAGE - DAY**

The entire Galactic team drives the peloton with power and dominance. ANDREA's teammate DAN rides up to him.

DAN
Mathias is boxed in. Should we try something?

ANDREA hesitates.

ANDREA
I don't know. He's smart, maybe he's trying to draw us out, make us slip up.

DAN
You're the leader. It's your call.

ANDREA thinks, then decides, his gaze steely.

ANDREA
Let's do it! We'll gutter them after Maasbracht.

DAN, acting as lieutenant, relays the order into the mic on his jersey.

DAN
Everyone, we gutter in 500 metres. Target Mathias. Let's blow it apart around him.

15 **INT. MEETING ROOM - KOREAN SOVEREIGN WEALTH FUND - PARIS - DAY**

MS YEO and her assistants are watching the race.

INSERT TV

The race heats up. The peloton snakes single-file behind GALACTIC, which gutters the group and blows it apart in a cloud of dust.

COMMENTATOR #1 (OFF-CAMERA)
There it is! GALACTIC makes the first move and gutters the peloton.

16 **EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - DUSSELDORF STAGE - DAY**

The TV feed snaps back to reality. We find MATHIAS who sees the move. AYDEN is still at his side.

MATHIAS
They're trying to screw us! If we get dropped here, it's over!

AYDEN registers the threat.

AYDEN
Take my wheel, I'll...

MATHIAS doesn't let him finish. He takes the front himself, driving the chase as the peloton explodes. Muscles taut, eyes like a killer.

MATHIAS with AYDEN on his wheel, veins bulging in his neck, fights like hell, tearing past riders by the dozen, dropping them without a word, without a glance.

After a relentless pursuit, he claws his way back to GALACTIC and saves a dire situation!

AYDEN slots back into line.

MATHIAS threads his way past the GALACTIC riders and pulls up shoulder to shoulder with ANDREA, showing his strength.

MATHIAS
(hard)
It'll take more than that,
teammate.

ANDREA doesn't answer.

17 **EXT. LIÈGE COUNTRYSIDE - DAY**

The peloton hurtles towards the finish line. AYDEN is next to the Deepblue car, listening to ERIK's instructions.

NORA sees him and smiles at him.

ERIK
Shelter Mathias to the finish. The
last stretch will catch you out.

AYDEN
I've got great legs today, coach! I
can attack them and take the
kilometre!

ERIK
Hey calm down. Just do as I tell
you! No discussion.

AYDEN shrugs and moves up the peloton, as ERIK watches on irritated.

ERIK (CONT'D)
Fucking wild horse!

18 **EXT. FAUBOURG DE LIÈGE - DAY**

AYDEN moves up through half the peloton and slips in front of MATHIAS who gives him a pat on the back as he passes. They exchange knowing glances. It seems AYDEN has accepted ERIK's instructions and is biding his time.

The peloton reaches the 3-kilometre banner and suddenly surges. It sparks something in AYDEN. He can't resist the pull of the finish and launches into a flat-out sprint.

MATHIAS
(screaming)
Stay where you are Ayden!

But AYDEN doesn't care, he accelerates further and reaches WILLIAM who is fighting to stay in the top 10 before the sprint. The peloton is already racing at more than 60 kph.

WILLIAM sees AYDEN.

WILLIAM
What are you doing here?!

AYDEN
I'll lead you out for the sprint!

WILLIAM
I don't need anyone. I race without a lead-out.

AYDEN
Trust me! I'll drop you off at 200 metres and you'll smash them!

WILLIAM smiles and nods, zipping up his jersey.

WILLIAM
Alright mate, let's have 'em!

They're both fired up.

19 **EXT. ENTRANCE TO LIÈGE - FLAMME ROUGE - DAY**

The peloton hurtles under the flamme rouge, tearing into Liège at breakneck speed. AYDEN is at the front, flat out, with WILLIAM on his wheel on the right-hand side of the road, locked in battle with three other sprint trains.

400 metres. We're close to WILLIAM, tucked perfectly into AYDEN's wheel, launched at full speed.

20 **EXT/INT. DEEPBLUE TEAM CAR / ENTRANCE TO LIÈGE - DAY**

NORA watches the finale on her phone, fingers crossed. It's the final sprint!

21 **EXT. FINISH STRAIGHT - LIÈGE - DAY**

AYDEN rises out of the saddle to unleash WILLIAM at full speed.

200 metres. WILLIAM signals that he wants to swing out to the right.

WILLIAM
Right! Right!!

But AYDEN misreads the signal and squeezes right! He shuts the door on WILLIAM, who is pinned against the barriers and crashes at high speed. Behind him, a dozen riders are wiped out, smashing into one another. A horrific pile-up.

22 **INT. MEETING ROOM - KOREAN SOVEREIGN WEALTH FUND - PARIS - DAY**

INSERT TV

The helicopter camera captures the chaos at the finish line.

COMMENTATOR #1 (OFF-CAMERA)
A dreadful scene here, a crash on stage one!

BACK TO THE SCENE

MS YEO and her assistants are shocked by this disastrous first stage. MS YEO gets up and leaves the room.

23 **EXT. FINISH ZONE - LIÈGE - DAY**

There's confusion at the finish line. AYDEN has put a foot down, staring at the chaos. There are broken bikes, blood on the tarmac.

WILLIAM lies on the ground with the other riders, attended to by the medical team.

AYDEN is in shock. He realises his mistake. ERIK walks up to him.

ERIK
I told you - cycling's no game.

CUT TO: BLACK.

24 **INT. AYDEN'S HOTEL ROOM - LIÈGE / TELEPHONE - EVENING**

AYDEN is sitting on the edge of the bed, looking distraught, still wearing his cycling gear.

His phone rings, it's ANNIE. He hesitates before resigning to answer, sadly and without enthusiasm.

AYDEN
Hello?

CHILDREN (OFF-CAMERA)
(all shouting together in
a joyful chaos)
HAPPY BIRTHDAY AY-DEN!!!

AYDEN smiles sadly.

25 **INT. LIVING ROOM - ANNIE'S HOUSE - MONTPELLIER / TELEPHONE -
EVENING**

ANNIE (60 years old), takes back the telephone while 6 kids
of different ages and backgrounds go back to messing around
behind her.

ANNIE
(very cheerfully)
Happy birthday, kid!

AYDEN
(smiling shyly)
Thanks Annie.

ANNIE
It's been ages! You need to call me
sometimes! How are you?

AYDEN
(unconvincingly)
I'm good, and you?

ANNIE
(to the children)
Hey! Gently!
(to Ayden)
Yeah, good. We've got a new little
boy in the house. He's like you
were at that age: sweet as
anything, but a bit of a daredevil.

AYDEN smiles, still down. The noise of the children grows
even louder.

ANNIE (CONT'D)
You should come and visit in the
summer, it would be great to see
you! What are you up to now in
Paris?

AYDEN tenses up even more.

AYDEN
Well... I... I'm still riding my
bike... Still doing deliveries.
Nothing new.

ANNIE is distracted by the noise behind her.

ANNIE
That's great, you be careful, won't
you!
(more noise)
Right, that's enough! Leave Marwa
alone!
(To Ayden)
Listen, do you mind if I call you
back later? I have to get dinner
ready for this lot before they
wreck the house.

AYDEN smiles and nods.

ANNIE (CONT'D)
Take care, kid. And happy birthday
again!!

ANNIE hangs up. Silence returns. AYDEN lingers for a moment,
his gaze empty and sad. Terribly alone.

26

INT. HOTEL RESTAURANT - LIÈGE - NIGHT

GAËL puts his plate of white rice, green beans and a turkey
escalope down on the table. He sits down looking grumpy.

GAËL
(unenthusiastically)
And so it begins, 3 weeks of rice
and turkey breast!

VICTOR
Give it here if you don't want it.

GAËL guards his plate.

The cyclists eat in silence. The mood is gloomy. AYDEN is
sitting on his own, he looks sad. Nobody is paying him any
attention.

ERIK, NORA and the other staff members eat at the next table
while engaging in conversation.

NORA
They'll be operating on William
tonight.

ERIK nods gravely.

NORA (CONT'D)
Losing our sprinter on day one
isn't exactly an encouraging start.

ERIK
Yeah, it's messed up! Blows the
whole plan to pieces. We'll have to
take the hits without flinching.

ERIK is interrupted by a door bursting open – JENNA walks in with a candle-lit birthday cake singing for AYDEN. Everyone joins in and the mood lifts. She sets the cake down in front of AYDEN who is totally surprised but can't bring himself to smile.

JENNA
You didn't think we'd forget did you?!

AYDEN turns to NORA who smiles at him.

VICTOR
Come on, blow it out! We all want a slice of cake!

AYDEN finally smiles shyly, and blows. Everyone applauds.

JENNA hands him a poorly wrapped gift which he opens: it's a packet of Pitch brioches.

GAËL
We all chipped in!

VICTOR grabs a slice of cake which is twice as big as MAËL's who sulks.

VICTOR
The biggest slice for the biggest thighs. Fair?

MAËL has no comeback.

MATHIAS sits down next to AYDEN.

AYDEN
(sad)
I'm sorry about Willy. I thought...

MATHIAS
(hard)
You screwed up. You never listen. Now you have to deal with the consequences.

AYDEN is floored. MATHIAS softens his tone.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
Guilt doesn't help anyone, alright? That's cycling. Willy screwed up too. He should never have let you lead him out for the sprint. You've got no experience, what did you expect?!

AYDEN keeps a sombre expression, he doesn't respond.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
(calmer)
He will have recovered in 4 weeks.
The collarbone is a rite of
passage. If you haven't broken it,
you're not a real rider. Right,
guys?

They all nod in agreement, mouths full, tugging at their
shirt collars to show off their the scars.

RÉDA
Milan-San Remo, 2016.

GAËL
French Championships, 2022.

MAËL
Tro Bro Leon, 2024. I can still
smell the burnt skin – like roast
pig.

MATHIAS shows his.

MATHIAS
Lombardy 2017...

Then he shows the other collarbone.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
And Paris-Nice 2021.

JOSÉ looks around, lost.

VICTOR shows his.

VICTOR
Punta Cana, 2019. Unlimited booze
in an all-inclusive, that hits just
as hard.

Everyone laughs except AYDEN who tries to join in but is
still floored by what MATHIAS said.

Back to NORA and ERIK who are watching the cyclists.

ERIK
You know Ayden put out more than
1,300 watts during that 20-second
sprint...

NORA
Is that a lot?

ERIK
It's huge. If only he could learn
to channel that energy...

NORA nods and watches AYDEN, who is isolated and sad.

27

INT. WILLIAM'S HOSPITAL ROOM - LIÈGE - NIGHT

The grey façade of an impersonal hospital building.

WILLIAM is in his bed. His shoulder is strapped while waiting to go into the operating theatre.

The door opens, it's AYDEN, looking sheepish.

WILLIAM
(surprised)
What the hell are you doing here!?
Does Erik know?

AYDEN
(shaking his head)
He would have never let me take the
car without a licence.

WILLIAM
(laughing)
You're insane, bro!

AYDEN
I wanted to say I'm sorry, for the
fall.

WILLIAM
(imitating devil's horns)
Don't worry about it mate, I'm
immortal!

AYDEN
I'm going to stop messing around
and...
(searching for his words)
Well, just do as I'm told.

WILLIAM listens, touched. AYDEN is about to leave.

WILLIAM
Don't let them put you in a cage...

AYDEN stops in the doorway.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
(seriously)
Racing isn't just a sport, it's an
addiction.

AYDEN turns, WILLIAM locks eyes with him.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
Some people are hooked on booze,
drugs, sex... but with you, it's
the finish line.

AYDEN listens, stunned.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
I saw it straight away. You only
live for the next stage, the next
corner, the next sprint. That's how
you're wired, man.

AYDEN cracks a knowing smile.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
If you fight against your nature,
you'll hang it up in a few months,
burnt out.

AYDEN is taken aback.

WILLIAM (CONT'D)
And then you'll have nothing.
Learnt nothing.
(driving it home)
You won't have found your place.

AYDEN reacts to the last phrase, lost in thought.

28 **INT. HOTEL GALACTIC - LIÈGE - NIGHT**

The GALACTIC racers are all gathered to analyse the video of
the last stage. Footage shows MATHIAS' impressive comeback.

MIKE, Galactic's sports director, cowboy hat and Texas drawl,
wraps up the briefing.

MIKE
...our data analysts dissected his
comeback and put his condition at
92%, on the rise.

ANDREA
(bitterly)
He's at the top of his game and
he's only going to get stronger. By
the third week he'll be on fire.

MIKE and the others nod.

ANDREA (CONT'D)
But I know him inside out. He got
away with it today through sheer
talent, but that positioning
mistake - it was no accident.
(darker)
(MORE)

ANDREA (CONT'D)
He's afraid of contact. He never
got over last year's crash...
Something's not right.

ANDREA points at MATHIAS' head.

ANDREA (CONT'D)
(laying out a menacing
plan)
If we can't beat his legs, we'll
get inside his head! Harass him,
and his teammates, kilometre after
kilometre, second after second.
Until he breaks.

Satisfied nods all around.

29 **EXT. NORTHERN ROAD - MONTAGE - DAY**

The following sequences are rapid-fire and tense. Nothing but stress and tension. GALACTIC gives no respite to MATHIAS nor DEEPBLUE.

In the heart of the peloton, the riders are flat out, the creaking of carbon, the screech of brakes, shouts of fear and warning, jaws clenched, muscles taut, dust and sweat. The strain and tension are palpable.

CUT TO:

Coming out of a bend, GALACTIC drives hard leaving MATHIAS in the wind. They take ANDREA to an intermediate sprint where he grabs 8 bonus seconds.

CUT TO:

A small breakaway battles for the stage. Behind, two chase groups: the first, GALACTIC in full force, an unstoppable steamroller; the second, all of DEEPBLUE driving the pace, trying to limit the damage, ten seconds behind.

CUT TO:

MATHIAS and DEEPBLUE are trailing at the rear. RÉDA pushes to help him close the gap, but MATHIAS waves him off, furious.

30 **INT/EXT. TEAM CAR / NORTHERN ROAD - MONTAGE - DAY**

NORA worriedly watches the team struggle. ERIK yells instructions over the radio, exasperated.

ERIK
To the front, dammit!

An animated graphic shows DEEPBLUE sliding down the GC. Times are tight at this stage of the Tour but the trend is not good, MATHIAS is 27th, 23 seconds off yellow. ANDREA is 8th, 11 seconds away.

31 **INT. DEEPBLUE BUS / NORTHERN ROAD - MONTAGE - DAY**

Alone in a corner, shirtless, MATHIAS pins his number to the jersey on his lap, his gaze is dark and intimidating.

32 **EXT. COUNTRY ROAD - MONTAGE - DAY**

Once again, the whole Galactic team are driving the peloton. ANDREA signals to DAN, who drifts back through the group to lean on MATHIAS, trying to box him in. MATHIAS won't give in. Maximum tension. A sharp corner looms. Neither rider backs off. Both go off the road! Luckily, there's no harm done. MATHIAS remounts, furious. VICTOR and JOSÉ, who have been waiting, bring their leader back into the peloton.

CUT TO:

The peloton pushes through a massive cloud of dust on a narrow dirt road. NORA and ERIK's car crawls behind, blocked by a dense crowd. The car struggles to move forward.

NORA

So many people! This is madness.

ERIK honks angrily. The car comes to a standstill. Kids, teens, men and women wave jerseys and signs, holding sandwiches and beers in their hands. A heaving throng of people, a moment suspended in time.

NORA takes it all in, stunned by the sheer joy of the fans.

She spots a four-year-old girl on her father's shoulders, eyes wide with wonder, waving to the passing riders. Time slows down.

NORA seems to slip into a memory. The little girl turns and their eyes meet. NORA is shaken.

Another honk shatters the reverie. NORA snaps back, still dazed.

ERIK

Come on, get moving, dammit!

CUT TO:

Back to the chaos of the race. Sprint in Épernay.

MATHIAS crosses the line, spent and frustrated.

INSERT SCREEN

MATHIAS's name appears, dropping to 43rd place at 39 seconds. ANDREA has already reached 4th, 14 seconds back.

BACK TO SCENE

MATHIAS stares at the screen, then turns his head and catches the worried gaze of NORA who is near the press zone.

33

INT. DEEPBLUE BUS - ÉPERNAY FINISH - DAY

The riders enter one by one, each looking dejected. They take their helmets and glasses off and collapse onto the seats with a sigh, worn out.

ERIK and NORA step into the bus. RÉDA barges past in a fury and storms up to MATHIAS.

RÉDA

(angry)

So, do we smash them or not!?

VICTOR

Calm down, Réda!

RÉDA

No way! For four stages they've been beating us up and we don't hit back! We look like cowards!

The others agree.

MAËL

(to Mathias)

Boss, just say the word and I'll crash into them myself, I don't give a shit!

MATHIAS

That's not how I race.

VICTOR

(bitter)

But that traitor doesn't hold back does he?

MATHIAS

(calm)

You just don't get it.

MATHIAS gets up, takes off his jersey, earpiece and heart-rate monitor. His body glistens with sweat and dust, his muscles are still swollen from the effort. His teammates stare, impressed.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
A few seconds here or there –
that's nothing but cheap tactics.
(more certain)
Tomorrow's the team time trial. No
excuses. Just us against ourselves.

The riders nod, re-energised by the words and confidence of their leader, who puts his jersey back on and drives the point home.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
We've got to finish this stage with
the taste of blood in our mouths.

Everyone approves and smiles. RÉDA gives a satisfied nod.

NORA meets MATHIAS' gaze, there is admiration in her eyes.

34 **INT. BAR / HOTEL RESTAURANT - LIÈGE - EVENING**

MATHIAS has slipped away to the bar to make a call.

MATHIAS
(gazing at the ground)
I just wanted to talk to him for a
minute.

MATHIAS' EX-WIFE (OFF-CAMERA)
He's asleep, Mathias! He's nine,
remember!

MATHIAS
I just thought that with the time
trial tomorrow he might need some
reassurance.

MATHIAS' EX-WIFE (OFF-CAMERA)
Of course he's anxious. It's best
just to leave him be, at least
until the race is over.

MATHIAS nods, his throat is tight, he's sad.

MATHIAS
Tell him... Tell him I promise I'll
be careful and...

MATHIAS' EX-WIFE (OFF-CAMERA)
(interrupting, sad)
Don't make promises you can't keep.

MATHIAS takes the comment, nods, and hangs up.

NORA approaches from the bar and spots him.

NORA

You okay?

MATHIAS nods half-heartedly, forces a smile, then turns – now side by side with NORA, close.

MATHIAS

It's my son. It's complicated...

NORA nods empathetically.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

We used to be inseparable. But since the accident...

(searching for words)

It's like... something's broken. I can't talk to him anymore.

NORA gently strokes his arm.

ERIK watches them suspiciously from a table nearby.

NORA

Are you nervous about tomorrow?
Does it bring back memories?

MATHIAS

(reassuring)

I'll be fine.

NORA

Were you close to Thibault?

MATHIAS

(thoughtful)

As close as you can be with a teammate. There's always a certain distance. That's hierarchy.

NORA nods.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)

(small smile)

And you? Does the crown feel heavy?

NORA answers with a knowing smile.

NORA

Yeah, but at least I don't have cameras on me and 200 guys coming after me.

MATHIAS

Sometimes one enemy is more dangerous than 200 opponents.

NORA
(teasing)
I've got an enemy?

MATHIAS
I don't know. It's not me, in any
case...

The tension between them is clear.

NORA
You're a great leader, Mathias.
I've always known that. And
tomorrow, you'll be greater still.
I'm sure of it.

MATHIAS holds her gaze, romantic tension.

ERIK doesn't take his eyes off them.

CUT TO:

Later, as MATHIAS leaves the restaurant, ERIK confronts him.

ERIK
A word, champ. What was that?

MATHIAS doesn't understand.

ERIK (CONT'D)
That little scene with Nora? You
think I don't see what you're up
to?

MATHIAS looks surprised, a faint smile appears on his lips.

ERIK (CONT'D)
I'm serious! This is no time to be
messing around. Especially not with
the boss! Your private life is your
business, but right now we're
racing. So zip it up and keep your
mind on the Tour, got it?!

MATHIAS stares back, defiant.

MATHIAS
Don't be jealous, Erik. You're the
only one on my mind. You can sleep
easy.

MATHIAS walks away, ERIK looks worried.

35

EXT. TECHNICAL ZONE - CAR PARK - ÉPERNAY - NIGHT

JENNA is mixing powder in dozens of bottles in front of the
parked team bus. She's on the phone, looking troubled.

Footsteps echo. JENNA hangs up. It's NORA.

NORA
I figured we could both use this
tonight?

NORA holds up a couple of mini vodka bottles.

JENNA beams.

36 **INT. DEEPBLUE BUS / UNDERGROUND CAR PARK - ÉPERNAY - NIGHT**

JENNA and NORA laugh loudly, sitting in the back of the bus in the dark. They're already more than tipsy.

JENNA
The first time Thibault and I
kissed he was in his cycling kit.
Thing is, when you're...happy,
those shorts don't hide much if you
know what I mean!

They burst out laughing and finish their drinks.

JENNA calms down, sadness creeps in.

JENNA (CONT'D)
My Thib...

NORA looks at her with empathy

NORA
Are you holding up? It can't be
easy to come back here.

JENNA thinks.

JENNA
You know, I was born into it,
raised on two wheels. With my dad,
my brother, my man, and all our
friends... they're not like
everyone else. Pain is all they
know.

NORA nods, hanging on JENNA's words.

JENNA (CONT'D)
I couldn't have stayed at home,
washing socks while waiting for the
hero to come back...

NORA
I get it. I watched my mum be at my
dad's beck and call all her life.

JENNA is surprised by the confession.

NORA (CONT'D)
Even when she got ill, she still
had to cook for him. Not a thank
you, or anything from my old man.

JENNA nods in solidarity.

NORA (CONT'D)
(firm)
I wasn't going to stay there and
take it, like she did. No-one was
going to run my life.

After a while, JENNA studies NORA.

JENNA
It's funny, when you turned up 8
months ago, I really thought you'd
quit after a week.

NORA smiles at her.

JENNA (CONT'D)
But you got it. I can see it in
your eyes.

NORA smile fades, she tenses up. After a moment.

NORA
(coldly)
My job is to turn companies around.
One I get what I came for here,
I'll move on to the next.

JENNA nods gravely, disappointed.

NORA (CONT'D)
You know Jenna... I'm not a nice
person.

JENNA
Nobody's nice in this business.

NORA downs another mini vodka bottle.

JENNA (CONT'D)
But despite the pressure, the
crashes, the backstabbing, the
rivalries... you live emotions here
you'll never live anywhere else.

NORA reflects.

JENNA (CONT'D)
Even after what happened to
Thibault, I wouldn't change a
thing. The Tour is our whole life.

NORA smiles back warmly.

JENNA (CONT'D)
It's the greatest show on earth.
Everyone can come, no matter their
means. We don't sell tickets at the
gate.

A spark lights up in NORA's eyes.

37 **INT. AYDEN'S HOTEL ROOM - ÉPERNAY - EVENING**

The room is pitch black. We can hear VICTOR snoring loudly.

AYDEN is in the other bed on his phone, his eyes are fixed on a video showing last season's DEEPBLUE mass crash.

INSERT VIDEO

Shot from a helicopter: rain pours down on a country road. DEEPBLUE, in team time trial formation, flying at full speed – when disaster strikes. One rider loses balance, the entire team crashes violently.

BACK TO SCENE

AYDEN stares at the video, we can feel his apprehension.

38 **INT/EXT. BALCONY / NORA'S HOTEL ROOM - ÉPERNAY - EVENING**

NORA is pacing up and down the balcony with the phone to her ear.

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
Ah! Finally! Did you get my
messages?

NORA notices MATHIAS on a balcony a few rooms away, absorbed in his phone, not seeing her.

NORA
(turning away, trying to
be discreet)
I've had an idea...

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
The Koreans are starting to have
doubts and...

NORA
Please, just listen...

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
(talking over her)
If your Mathias doesn't get moving,
you can kiss those 4 million
goodbye!

NORA
(blurting out loudly)
Will you listen, for fuck's sake!

MATHIAS looks over, in surprise.

NORA flashes him an apologetic smile, turns away and steps
inside her room.

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
Have you been drinking?

NORA
(not answering)
Do you remember the Rad Race?

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
In the warehouse? Where you found
Ayden?

NORA
Yes! They charged five euros at the
door and....

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
(impatient)
Yeah, and?

NORA
12 million people watch the Tour
every year. 12 million! Imagine if
we charged admission...

Silence. RAPHAËL thinks.

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
There's no way! And even if it was
possible... You're at the bottom of
the GC. You have no legitimacy, no
clout with the powers that be...

NORA
For now.

RAPHAËL (OFF-CAMERA)
If you want to blow up the system,
you need to be Real Madrid, not
Guingamp. You'll never get it
through!

NORA
(determined)
I'm not imposing. I'm convincing.

39 **EXT. TOUR VILLAGE - SAINT MALO - DAY**

The next morning the Tour roadshow has rolled into Saint Malo. Technicians put up barriers, assemble the start podium...

Trucks roll in and out. The public gathers, international journalists broadcast and interview riders in time-trial gear.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
Our number one rival is GALACTIC!

40 **INT. DEEPBLUE BUS - SAINT MALO - INTERCUT - DAY**

Smiles from the riders as they listen to ERIK's briefing. NORA stands beside him. The moment is serious. Intercut with MIKE, GALACTIC's sports director, giving his own briefing.

ERIK
With a leader you know well and
we're going to settle the score
with him!

The riders are all fired up.

41 **INT. GALACTIC BUS - SAINT MALO - INTERCUT - DAY**

Inside GALACTIC's bus, MIKE delivers his briefing too. He uses numbers, projected on a big screen. Impersonal. ANDREA, at the centre, listens intently.

MIKE
(confident)
We'll ride at 6.2 watts per kilo
for the first ten kilometres,
swapping every 8 seconds.

CUT TO:

ERIK
We've got one last shot to bounce
back before the mountains. And it's
today!

CUT TO:

MIKE

The key is composure. No getting carried away. We've got this. We're the best.

CUT TO:

ERIK

(fired up)

The course may be flat, but today we climb a goddamn mountain!

CUT TO:

MIKE

It's one more step towards the Champs-Élysées. Nothing more, nothing less. Keep calm. Build up the power, little by little. Here's the chart. It's on your bars too.

An animation shows the power curve on the projector screen.

CUT TO:

ERIK

It's been drilled into you since you were kids: don't go out too hard in a time trial.

The riders nod.

ERIK (CONT'D)

Today, we're doing the exact opposite. We're going full throttle! Like animals!

The riders look uncertain. ERIK continues.

ERIK (CONT'D)

Andrea is the type of guy who constantly doubts himself.

MATHIAS nods.

ERIK (CONT'D)

If we're ahead at the first checkpoint, it'll crush him with pressure. He'll push his teammates to blow up 10 km later, and then we'll destroy them.

Smiles break out.

ERIK (CONT'D)

If you trust me, we're still in the fight for the podium!

The riders nod.

ERIK (CONT'D)
If not, it's over.

Grave nods all around.

ERIK (CONT'D)
Ayden, you're the least experienced
but you've got the power. Leave
your brain on the bus, just follow
orders to the letter this time.

AYDEN nods.

NORA signals that she believes in him. MATHIAS stands and
takes the floor.

MATHIAS
(as leader)
We crashed here a year ago. As a
team. Today, we rise again. As a
team. We're not riding for
ourselves – we're riding for those
who aren't here anymore.

That sends shivers through the group. Everyone is galvanised.

The riders get up, more fired up than ever.

NORA watches as MATHIAS gives AYDEN a brotherly pat, then
pauses at JENNA, who has tears in her eyes. He gives her a
long and tight hug.

MATHIAS heads out, locking eyes with NORA. Romantic tension.

42

EXT. START ZONE / SAINT MALO - DAY

MATHIAS's expression is now hard and focused. DEEPBLUE and
GALACTIC are waiting in the start area. No-one is speaking.
Each rider is in their own bubble.

GALACTIC roll up to the start podium. ANDREA passes MATHIAS.
They can't avoid each other, and finally speak.

ANDREA
Strange, isn't it?

MATHIAS
The last time we rode together was
exactly a year ago. Same race.

ANDREA
Now it's every man for himself.

MATHIAS nods, melancholic.

ANDREA (CONT'D)
Don't screw it up this time.
Thibault's leg was a high enough
price, don't you think?

MATHIAS
You bastard!

MATHIAS lunges at ANDREA, about to grab him. Their teammates separate them.

ANDREA walks away to the start with a sly smile - satisfied to have unsettled MATHIAS with his cruel words.

43 **EXT. START PODIUM / PADDOCK - SAINT MALO - DAY**

The teams roll out one by one from the podium, eight across.

GALACTIC are off...

Finally, DEEPBLUE, reduced to 7, take their place on the podium.

A solemn suspended moment in time. Focused, tense faces. The countdown begins...

44 **INT. OFFICE - KOREAN SOVEREIGN WEALTH FUND - PARIS - DAY**

5... MS YEO watches the race alone from her office.

45 **INT. LIVING ROOM - ANNIE'S HOUSE - MONTPELLIER - DAY**

4... ANNIE manages a room full of kids while the Tour is showing on the TV.

INSERT TV

AYDEN in close-up on the start podium, utterly focused.

BACK TO SCENE

ANNIE recognises AYDEN, stunned.

46 **INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - BREST - DAY**

3... THIBAUT finally stops coughing. He looks pale. He's watching from his hospital bed with a proud and determined expression despite his frail health.

47 **INT. DEEPBLUE BUS - MONT SAINT MICHEL FINISH - DAY**

2... JENNA and the staff are tense, watching the race on a screen. JENNA wrings her hands, barely hiding her anxiety.

48

INT. HOUSE OF MATHIAS' EX-WIFE - BREST - DAY

1... MATHIAS' EX-WIFE is also watching the start of DEEPBLUE.
MATHIAS' face fills the screen.

Hidden in the stairwell, MARCEL watches the screen, looking worried.

0...

INSERT TV

DEEPBLUE sets off.

COMMENTATOR #1 (OFF-CAMERA)
And DEEPBLUE are off!

COMMENTATOR #2 (OFF-CAMERA)
They'll need the ride of their
lives if they want to fight for the
podium!

49

EXT. COASTAL ROAD NEAR MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY

The teams ride alone against the clock, Mont Saint Michel looming in the distance, at the finish line.

DEEPBLUE are riding in formation but they're disorganised.
Frustration

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
(from the car)
More power guys, and stay aero!
First checkpoint coming up. keep
pushing. Come on!

MATHIAS surges, a fighting expression on his face.

CUT TO:

In the GALACTIC car, MIKE watches real-time power data for his team with satisfaction.

All of GALACTIC are settled on their bikes, riding in perfect formation, a sharp contrast to the chaos of DEEPBLUE.

MIKE
Perfect job, guys! Keep it steady.
On my signal, everyone push 10 more
watts.

CUT TO:

DEEPBLUE reach the first checkpoint.

MATHIAS
We're fourth, 19 seconds down on
Galactic. Time to step on it. Give
it everything!

They accelerate but the timing is still off.

MATHIAS re-centres them over the radio.

MATHIAS (CONT'D)
Back to the routine, just like we
did in training. Synch up. We've
worked too hard. Let's look them in
the eyes, we belong here too,
dammit!

It works, we see greater concentration and the hunger to win
on their faces.

MATHIAS drives forward, pulling his 6 teammates with him.

AYDEN follows instructions and blends into the group.

CUT TO:

Back inside GALACTIC. They are flawlessly synchro. They look
unbeatable. Machines.

Then disaster! ANDREA's rear wheel slips dangerously.

ANDREA panics and screams into the radio.

ANDREA
Flat! Rear flat.

MIKE (OFF-CAMERA)
Stay calm. We've got you.

ANDREA pulls over, panicking all the same. He waves
frantically for help. A GALACTIC mechanic picks up another
bike and rushes to him.

ANDREA
Hurry up! Dammit.

ANDREA jumps on while the rest of the team waits.

The clock is ticking as the mechanic pushes him off on the
replacement bike. He starts hammering hard. But something's
wrong. Furious, ANDREA screams into the earpiece.

ANDREA (CONT'D)
Stupido!!! This isn't my bike!!! I
can't ride this thing!

Chaos is the GALACTIC support car which stops again. Another
mechanic scrambles to find ANDREA's real bike, cursing, while
the whole team are at a standstill.

INSERT TV

The scene is broadcast live onto the screen in the DEEPBLUE car. DEEPBLUE blast past GALACTIC, who restart in total disarray.

COMMENTATOR #1 (OFF-CAMERA)
Incredible! Deepblue are catching
Galactic up, they're taken back two
minutes!

BACK TO SCENE

NORA is both stunned and delighted. She watches GALACTIC vanish in the rear window.

NORA
What the hell just happened?!

ERIK
I've never seen anything like it!

NORA
Why did they stop?

ERIK
(as if obvious)
They waited for their leader. What
else could they do?!

NORA reflects on this.

CUT TO:

Back to within the DEEPBLUE team.

The group tightens, now perfectly in sync, flying like fighter planes over the small coastal road!

RÉDA
We've got them! Push harder!

The high tide and the magnificent Mont Saint Michel are in the distance. Second checkpoint.

ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
(euphoric)
First at the second checkpoint!
Come on!!

The news fires up the team even more. They reach insane speeds. DEEPBLUE is now running like a well-oiled machine.

50

INT. LIVING ROOM - ANNIE'S HOUSE - MONTPELLIER - DAY

ANNIE is sitting with her kids. She anxiously watches while scrolling for news on her phone.

51 **INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - BREST - DAY**

THIBAULT sits up, tense, cheering his teammates as if he were at a stadium.

52 **INT. MATHIS' EX-WIFE'S HOUSE - BREST - DAY**

MARCEL, still hiding in the stairwell, can't take his eyes off the screen, clutching his stuffed toy tight as he watches his father and the team.

53 **INT. DEEPBLUE BUS / HOTEL CAR PARK - SAINT MALO - DAY**

JENNA and the staff are standing in front of the screen, watching the team's feat. They thump each other's shoulders, fists clenched, buzzing with nerves.

54 **EXT. COASTAL ROAD NEAR MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY**

 ERIK (OFF-CAMERA)
 (ultra-hyped)
Seventeen K left, boys. Step it up!
Time's taken on the fourth rider.
Come on, come on, come on!

MATHIAS holds the team together, eyes locked ahead, when suddenly...

Flashes: the speed, the danger, riders brushing shoulders just centimetres apart.

THIBAULT in hospital.

His amputated leg.

MARCEL running to his bedroom as MATHIAS trains on his home-trainer.

NORA's eyes.

The fight with ANDREA.

All of DEEPBLUE sprawled on the ground, the team car smashed. Tarmac rushing by, terrifyingly close.

MATHIAS is seized by a panic attack.

VICTOR notices his leader's face contorting.

 VICTOR
 You alright, boss?

The flashes intensify, panic flooding MATHIAS. He cracks. The formation falls apart. The group slows, exploding in disarray.

CUT TO:

NORA and ERIK watch the chaos unfold from the car.

ERIK
What the hell's going on?!

RÉDA (OFF-CAMERA)
Mathias is in trouble.

ERIK
For fuck's sake!

ERIK slams the dashboard and sees the telemetry: MATHIAS is adrift, dropped.

ERIK (CONT'D)
It's over. We'll slip 3 minutes. It was too good to be true.

NORA thinks hard.

ERIK grabs the radio, resigned.

ERIK (CONT'D)
(beaten)
Alright, let's slow it down and wait for Mathias, regroup and...

NORA snatches the radio from his hands. ERIK is in shock.

NORA
Forget him! Pick it up again!

Through the windscreen NORA sees the riders hesitate, confused. She grips the mic tighter.

NORA (CONT'D)
(cold, steady)
That's an order! Do it!

CUT TO:

DEEPBLUE kick again.

MATHIAS is dropped. He struggles to claw back but he's already far behind, overtaken by GALACTIC.

DEEPBLUE tear ahead, trying to reform.

CUT TO:

In the car, NORA clutches the radio, eyes blazing. ERIK sits stunned, powerless before her resolve.

NORA (CONT'D)
Ayden, you take the lead. You were born for this. It's your turn to carry the team.

CUT TO:

MATHIAS reels from the order, digs in harder, stung, but it's too late.

CUT TO:

AYDEN's expression hardens. He drives forward.

The riders are spent. JOSÉ is the first to crack, then RÉDA, crushed by the effort. AYDEN presses on, with VICTOR, GAËL and MAËL clinging on.

55 **INT. WILLIAM'S HOSPITAL ROOM - DAY**

WILLIAM watches the race on TV after his operation, eyes fixed with pride on AYDEN leading the team.

INSERT TV

AYDEN pushes harder still, dragging the three others with him.

COMMENTATOR #1 (OFF-CAMERA)
This is absolutely incredible!
Deepblue, now driven by one of its
youngest riders, is in the lead...

56 **EXT. COASTAL ROAD NEAR MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY**

Suddenly, the Mont St Michel appears, and the finish line.
200m... 100m...

The final straight. AYDEN and his teammates storm in at breakneck speed, the crowd roars.

AYDEN gives one last push and crosses first, followed closely by his three teammates.

A moment suspended in time: no sound, as if no-one can yet process what's just happened.

57 **INT. DEEPBLUE BUS / FINISH PADDOCK - MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY**

JENNA and the staff erupt in joy. The sound slams back, deafening.

58 **INT/EXT. DEEPBLUE CAR - COASTAL ROAD NEAR MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY**

ERIK and NORA explode in celebration too.

59 **INT. LIVING ROOM - ANNIE'S HOUSE - MONTPELLIER - DAY**

ANNIE stares at AYDEN on TV, stunned. She tries to call him but he obviously doesn't answer.

60 **INT. MEETING ROOM - KOREAN SOVEREIGN WEALTH FUND - PARIS - DAY**

MS YEO watches Deepblue's triumph with satisfaction.

61 **INT. MATHIAS' EX-WIFE'S HOUSE - BREST - DAY**

MATHIAS' EX-WIFE turns to see her son hiding in the stairwell. She gives him a small smile. MARCEL says nothing, turns away and heads up to his room clutching his toy.

62 **INT. GALACTIC BUS / FINISH PADDOCK - MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY**

Inside, KATRINE watches the screens as MATHIAS rolls in alone, broken.

63 **EXT. FINISH AREA MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY**

NORA stands amid the chaos, torn between pride and pure joy.

MATHIAS arrives two minutes down and passes her without a glance.

On the giant screen graphics confirm: AYDEN is the new yellow jersey of the Tour de France.

The noise swells again.

64 **EXT. FINISH PODIUM MONT SAINT MICHEL - DAY**

NORA watches the ecstatic crown, her phone in hand.

AYDEN climbs onto the podium and pulls on the leader's jersey, handed to him by ROMAIN BARDET.

RAPHAËL appears in the crowd, grinning, moving toward NORA who's surprised to see him.

NORA
(smiling)
Why didn't you tell me you were coming?!

RAPHAËL
(euphoric)
This is huge! The Koreans are going to go wild!

NORA
(calm)
I'm not signing the deal.

RAPHAËL's smile vanishes.

RAPHAËL
Are you insane!? We've been working
on this for months! Why back out
now?!

NORA smiles, sure of herself.

NORA
Look. That's our deal.

RAPHAËL turns to the podium where AYDEN stands in yellow, in
front of a cheering crowd.

NORA (CONT'D)
Now we've got legitimacy, don't you
think?

Nearby, MATHIAS spots RAPHAËL by NORA's side. His expression
hardens.

NORA (CONT'D)
We're not talking 4 million
anymore. We're talking 40 or 100...

Silence. RAPHAËL thinks and starts to understand.

RAPHAËL
(challenging)
You want to set the country on
fire?

NORA
(resolute)
No. The whole world.

At that moment, JENNA rushes up with a phone.

JENNA
(looking surprised)
Apparently it's urgent...

NORA takes it, confused.

ANNIE (OFF-CAMERA)
Ms Menia?

NORA
(blocking the noise)
Yes?

ANNIE (OFF-CAMERA)
Sorry to bother you, but as I told
your secretary, I can't get hold of
Ayden and...

NORA
Sorry, but who is this?

ANNIE (OFF-CAMERA)
I'm Annie Rinfer, I've looked after
Ayden since he was little.

NORA
(unsettled)
Okay... What can I do for you?
Annie (o.S)
(shaken)
I don't understand. He told me he
was working as a delivery boy in
Paris, and now I see him on TV in
the Tour de France! Do you even
know the risks you're putting him
under?!

NORA (CONT'D)
(now alarmed)
What risks? What are you talking
about?

JENNA signals to NORA, worried.

ANNIE (OFF-CAMERA)
(struggling)
He has a serious heart condition!
Cycling is VERY dangerous for him!

NORA reels, stunned, under the eyes of JENNA and RAPHAËL.

On the podium, AYDEN beams, arms raised high, the yellow
jersey on his chest. Overwhelmed, but radiant.

END OF EPISODE 2